The Lighthouse Keeper's Almanac

Chapter 1: The Arrival

In the autumn of 1887, Elias Marrow took the post of keeper at Gull Point Lighthouse, a white tower on a spit of black rock off the northern coast. He was forty-one, a widower, and had spent twenty years as a ship's carpenter before a fall from a mast ended his sailing days. The Lighthouse Board gave him a lamp to tend, a cottage with two rooms, and a salary of four hundred dollars a year.

The tower stood ninety feet tall and held a first-order Fresnel lens that had been shipped from Paris in forty crates. Elias's predecessor, a gruff man named Tobias Penhale, stayed three days to teach him the routine: wind the clockwork that turned the lens every four hours, trim the wicks, polish the brass, and log the weather every morning at six. Penhale left on the supply boat, the Margaret Ann, without saying goodbye to the lamp he had tended for nineteen years.

Chapter 2: The Great Storm

In November, a storm the locals later called the Great Gale of 1887 struck the coast. For three nights Elias did not sleep. Waves climbed the rock and broke against the tower's base, and spray reached the lantern room at the very top. On the second night, the clockwork failed. Elias climbed the stairs, one hundred and twelve of them, and turned the lens by hand for nine hours so that ships would still see the rotating beam.

At dawn the schooner Halcyon limped into the bay with her mainmast gone. Her captain, a woman named Ruth Aldane, rowed to the rock and told Elias that his light was the only reason her crew of eleven survived. Elias said he had only done the job. She left him a gift: a brass compass engraved with the words "Keep the light."

Chapter 3: The Almanac

During the long winter, Elias began keeping an almanac. Each evening he wrote down the tide, the wind, the birds he saw, and one thing he had learned that day. He had never been a reader, but Ruth Aldane sent him a crate of books by the spring supply boat, and he made himself read ten pages every night after lighting the lamp. He wrote that the habit saved him: on nights when he felt lonely, ten pages was a small enough promise to keep.

By June he had finished Moby-Dick, which he complained was too long, and Robinson Crusoe, which he said was about a man who needed a better carpenter. The almanac records that he lost his place often, and so he began tying a strip of red cloth into each book as a marker.

Chapter 4: The Visitor

In August 1888, an inspector named Walter Finch arrived unannounced to examine the station. He found the brass polished, the logbooks complete, and the almanac on the kitchen table. Finch read several pages and asked whether the keeper wrote for anyone. Elias said he wrote for the next keeper, so that whoever came after him would not be as alone as he had been.

Finch's report praised the station as the best-kept on the northern coast and recommended a raise to four hundred and fifty dollars. Elias kept the post until 1911. The almanac, eleven volumes in all, now sits in the maritime museum in the town of Port Harlow.